Design notes

DIY CNC epoxy-granite mill · October 2026

Fixed-gantry, epoxy-granite desktop mill sized like the Shariff DMC2 Mini (180 x 300 x 140 mm travel), with a 2020/ACM enclosure mounted on the base and a clear lift-up door.

This document explains the design: the frame, the coolant system, the stiffness study and the cost. The repository layout and the rebuild commands are in the top-level `README.md`.

Frame

Five castings that bolt together. Each is a **steel skeleton** of laser-cut plates (and four tube columns in the uprights), slotted together and clamped with threaded rod, cast into **epoxy granite**, which damps it and adds stiffness. The steel is the frame: every joint between castings, and every rail, riser and ballscrew support, bolts steel to steel. Nothing is welded, and nothing is threaded into the epoxy granite (the enclosure's 11 M5 inserts are the only ones left).

Module	Steel skeleton	Joins to
Base, two halves	A grid of slotted plates per half: a girder under each Y rail (tapped rail bar on top, web, bottom bar, end plates), a pedestal under each upright (seat plate, two webs, bottom bar), cross plates at the split and under the Y ballscrew supports (tapped pads), plates down to the legs	The halves meet end plate to end plate on four dowel pins, clamped by two 1/2-13 draw rods that run along the girders from a front pocket to a back pocket. The front half is cast against the rear, so the joint fits by construction
Upright (x2), a raked buttress	A 3/8 in foot plate, two 2x2 tube columns, a brace plate up the slope, the two-layer 1/2 in top plate; O-ring groove under the foot	Its foot plate bears on the base pedestal's seat plate. Three 1/2-13 tie rods (two inside the columns, from nuts held in the top plate; one from the toe, onto the foot plate) run right through the pedestal to its bottom bar. Two dowels, grouted into the foot at first assembly, locate it
Beam (140 deep x 140 high)	A box: a tapped 3/8 in face plate (the rail face), a back plate, five diaphragms, and a seat and a cap plate at each end	The seat plates bear on the upright top plates; at each end four 3/8-16 x 6-1/2 in grade 8 bolts clamp cap plate, box and seat plate down into the top plate, and a dowel (grouted at first assembly) locates it

Nothing you buy gets cut. The rails (including the 600 mm Y pair) and ballscrews are used at the lengths they're sold in; the tube is bought at length (8 in columns, 6 in legs); the risers and aluminum plates are ordered cut to size; the skeleton plates are laser cut from the DXFs in `docs/1-sourcing/laser/` (about 64 parts, 48 kg). The only cutting left is the 1/2-13 threaded rod. The only machining is tapping (the top plates, the base rail bars and pads, the beam face plate) and drilling and tapping the risers. Use plain steel, not galvanized: epoxy bonds poorly to zinc. Wire-brush off rust and loose scale and degrease just before casting; paint only the part of each leg that hangs below the base.

Keeping the epoxy down. About 9.6 kg of epoxy (8.5 % of the 113 kg the castings would weigh with sand; 121 kg with the alumina):

- The columns and legs stay hollow. Printed rings and plugs close their ends so no mix gets in.
- Every skeleton plate has windows, so the epoxy granite runs through and locks onto both faces.

- The base's underside pockets follow the stiffness study below, with the steel grid in the ribs between them: two full-depth girders (80 mm wide) under the table rails, a full-depth tie between them across the split, a full-depth rib across the front of each upright foot and another along the split, and a 20 mm top skin almost everywhere else, including over pockets under the upright feet that keep clear of the band under each upright where the pedestal runs. The 70 mm front wall carries the coolant trough. Every pocket is open to the bottom, so the cores (printed shells or foam blocks) pull straight out; a few are shallow steps (40 or 65 mm deep) under the trough band, the draw rods, the knees and outboard of the pedestals (`base_pockets` in `model/build_cnc.py`).

Molds and fits. The molds are a kit (`model/moldbox.py`, the mold guide): melamine boards with every wall 25 mm above the pour line, held by printed brackets and saddles with M4 bolts through that band, so no bolt passes through a cast face. Every printed piece bolts to its board from outside into a captive nut (a bayonet pocket in the face against the board), or pins on if it is too thin, and pieces cut to fit the printer are pegged together. The hidden pocket cores are XPS foam, which keeps the printing to 1.1 kg of PETG (sliced in Bambu Studio). A clash check in the model keeps the kit, the boards, the castings and the steel apart. Two joints are made to fit by construction instead of by measuring: the front base half is cast against the rear half (flush top faces, matching split faces, end plates straight onto the dowel pins), and the dowels are grouted into oversize holes at first assembly, so two independent molds don't have to agree.

- The mix matters as much as the geometry. Use a well-graded aggregate (gravel up to about 10 mm, sand, fine sand, and whiting, i.e. calcium carbonate powder) and vibrate it. The split in the build guide follows a modified Fuller curve, P(d) = (d^q - d_min^q) / (D^q - d_min^q) with D = 10 mm and q about 0.45: q = 0.5 (classic Fuller) is a little coarse and needs more epoxy to wet, q = 0.37 (Andreasen) packs tighter but its extra powder soaks up epoxy.
- **Aluminum oxide in the beam and uprights.** Alumina grit (E about 370 GPa for brown fused, a little less for black, against about 70 for quartz and granite) replaces the sand, volume for volume, in those three castings only (`analysis/alumina.py`): brown #16 for the coarse sand, black 70 grit for the fine sand. A differential-effective-medium estimate of the mix (the plain mix comes out at 34 GPa, close to the 30 GPa the frame model uses) puts it 22 % stiffer with the #16 alone, 10 % with the 70 grit alone and 37 % with both. On the frame, both come to about +17 / +16 / +21 % in X / Y / Z for $150 (a 50 lb and a 25 lb bag); the #16 alone is about +10 %. Doing the base as well would take about 60 kg more grit for another 8-11 %. It's an estimate, so the build guide's tap-tested bars check it, and sand is the fallback. Other options: **Graded industrial quartz** (Agsco and similar) is clean, dry and consistent but costs more and ships heavy; pool filter sand is the local equivalent. **Ceramic microspheres** (Zeeospheres) help the mix flow at low epoxy, but whiting does most of that for far less. **Epoxy grout** (Laticrete SpectraLock) is fine for a test bar or a repair, but it's fine-grained (about 15-20 % binder) and far too expensive for 130 kg. Whiting is used instead of silica flour because it has no crystalline silica: a plain dust mask is enough. A good mix gets to 8.5 % epoxy, which fits a single 3 gal kit (10 % needs a second, small kit); the build guide's jar test and test bars check it before anything is cast.

What the rails and supports bolt to. Steel. The rails screw into steel risers, and the risers are bedded on the castings with a thin epoxy grout and held down by counterbored M5 screws (under the rail, between its own screws) into the skeleton: the base's tapped rail bars (Y) and the beam's tapped face plate (X). The Y ballscrew supports (BK12/BF12) bolt into tapped pads on the base grid's cross plates; the X supports (BK10/BF10) into the beam's face plate. Behind every tapped hole the casting is relieved, where the greased mold screw stood. The Z axis mounts on the aluminum plates.

Load path. A cutting force goes spindle, Z plate, Z and X blocks, X rails, steel risers, the beam's face plate and its steel box; at each end the seat plate bears on the upright's top plate, clamped by four 3/8-16 grade 8 bolts; down the upright's columns and brace to its foot plate, which bears on the base pedestal's seat plate; the three tie rods clamp that whole stack (top plate, columns, foot plate, seat, pedestal webs, bottom bar) from the top plate to the nuts under

the base; across the base grid (cross plates, girders, the split end plates on their dowel pins, clamped by the draw rods); and back up through the Y rail bars, risers, rails and blocks to the table. Steel all the way, and every nut and bolt in that chain can be reached and retightened: the tie-rod nuts under the base and in the toe pockets, the draw-rod nuts in the front and back pockets, the cap screws on the beam top. The epoxy granite around it is in compression where the rods clamp and everywhere it fills between the plates; it damps the frame and adds about half its stiffness again. The stiffness study treats it as bonded to the steel, which the windows in every plate (the casting runs through and locks both faces) and the clamping are for.

The steel is bolted, not welded. A welded skeleton would have to be welded before casting (and pulls out of square doing it) or after (the heat ruins the epoxy next to it), and it would make the frame one piece. Slotted plates go together square without a jig, the slots and the mold screws put every tapped face where the templates say, and the five castings still come apart.

Steel tolerances. The plates are laser cut, so they're good to a few tenths. The tube is bought at length, and a supplier's saw cut is only good to about 1/8 in, with A500 tube about 0.5 mm off nominal and a weld seam inside; each tube is set from one end and its other end has room (`tube_cut_tol`, checked in the report). Each column is clamped up against its top plate, its foot in a 4.8 mm epoxy bed on the foot plate; each leg is pushed up against its leg plate, its leveling foot taking up the rest; the rods are screwed up flush at one end and have a 6 mm tail past the far nut. The printed rings that center the columns on their rods have 0.5 mm a side (`tube_fit`) and grooves for the seam. If the tube that arrives is further off, put its calipered sizes in `frame_tube` / `post_tube` and re-run before printing.

The enclosure's 2020 frame bolts to the base top with angle brackets into cast-in M5 inserts, so the base is the enclosure floor. Seal the top with an epoxy gel coat; coolant runs to the two drains at the front. The door laps over the base front face.

Assembly: base halves (end plates onto the dowel pins, tighten the draw rods), uprights (dowels grouted into the feet the first time, tighten the tie rods), beam (cap screws), axes, enclosure. To break it down, take the X and Y motors off first (they pass through the enclosure panels), then reverse the order. Heaviest piece: the rear base half (about 42 kg). The upright feet run forward across the base split, so the base halves have to be joined before the uprights go on.

Stiffness study (`analysis/`)

A finite-element model of the frame was used to see where the epoxy granite does the most good, and a topology optimization was run on the base.

Model. The castings and cast-in steel are voxelized from this model at 10 mm (66k brick elements). Each voxel's stiffness is its mix of epoxy granite (E = 30 GPa) and steel; the joints between castings are treated as bonded, which is what the preload is for. A 1 kN force on the tool goes into the beam through the X blocks (the X component through the X ballscrew to its BK bearing) and, reversed, into the base through the Y blocks (the Y component through the Y screw to its BK). The result is the frame's own stiffness at the tool, tool against work, for X at the center and end, the table at both ends and the center, and the tool 50 mm above the table. Rails, blocks, screws and the spindle are not in it; the screws alone are roughly 30-50 N/um, so the frame should stay well above that.

Findings (frame only, N/um at the tool, mean over the load cases):

Frame	Epoxy granite	X	Y	Z
Previous design	42.4 L	48.9	80.7	57.9

Frame	Epoxy granite	X	Y	Z
Same, base made rigid		87.2	130.9	80.2
Same, uprights rigid		83.3	103.9	102.6
Same, beam rigid		122.9	175.7	125.9
Base with no pockets at all (+14 L)	56.8 L	61.5	90.1	67.0
Beam 120 -> 140 mm deep only (+1.5 L)	43.9 L	51.1	90.9	63.8
Optimized base + 140 mm beam	43.7 L	54.0	94.5	68.0
+ riser hold-downs, support pads, uncut 600 mm Y rails	43.7 L	55.7	96.8	68.9
Base + uprights optimized together, same material (free-form uprights)	43.7 L	63.9	103.3	85.2
Raked-buttress uprights, base re-laid around them	52.6 L	77.5	107.5	93.0
+ blunt upright toe, rounded edges, deeper slope pockets	53.0 L	78.2	110.1	95.5
+ alumina grit in the beam and uprights (estimate)	53.0 L	91.3	127.3	115.7
Lighter base (pockets under the upright feet, 20 mm skin), 9 kg less	49.5 L	84.3	124.5	111.1
Same, tie rods not counted as glued in (they sit in clearance holes; the rows below do the same; `vox_before_chain`)	49.3 L	81.6	121.9	107.6
+ tie rods right through the base to steel anchor bars, two-layer top plates	50.5 L	86.8	124.7	111.6
+ posts and sockets taken out, a second dowel per foot	52.4 L	86.3	124.2	110.1
+ upright feet 260 mm ahead of the beam (from 290)	51.3 L	84.2	123.0	109.3
+ steel skeletons in the uprights and a steel box in the beam (all 3/8 in)	47.9 L	96.0	132.7	130.9
+ steel grids in the base (all 3/8 in)	45.8 L	107.1	153.5	138.1
Now: webs, cross plates and braces 1/4 in with windows, 3/8 in foot plates	**48.5 L**	**99.7**	**146.9**	**124.7**

- **Steel skeletons.** Making the steel the frame (laser-cut plates slotted together, tube columns, everything clamped by rods and bolts, epoxy granite cast round it) makes the frame +18 / +19 / +14 % stiffer than the last all-epoxy-granite design, with modes 136 / 277 / 299 Hz, for about 24 kg more (59 kg of steel and hardware against 26, 121 kg of castings against 130). All-3/8 in plate was stiffer still (+27 / +25 / +26 %) but 11 kg heavier again. A 120 mm deep beam would save another 4 kg and still beat the old frame (96.1 / 130.1 / 112.5, modes 138 / 280 / 300 Hz); shorter upright feet run the front foot pockets past their mold bridges.

- **The steel chain** (tie rods from the top plates to anchor bars under the base) is worth +6 / +2 / +4 % (the bars, the thicker top plates and the solid band left under each foot together). It also makes the posts redundant: with the feet clamped through steel they were worth under 1.5 %, so they're gone, and with them the sockets, the post bushings and the post grouting (a second grouted dowel per foot locates it instead). The stiffness left over paid for 30 mm off each upright foot. The frame ends up +3 / +1 / +2 % stiffer than before the chain, with modes 136 / 268 / 303 Hz (from 132 / 265 / 282), and about 6 kg heavier (the bars and the thicker top plates). A 250 mm foot keeps the static stiffness but drops mode 2 below the old frame; shorter than that the front foot pockets run past their mold bridges. Thinner uprights and a thinner front wall didn't pay.

- The beam is the biggest share of the deflection, then the base and the uprights about equally. Liter for liter, epoxy in the beam is worth roughly ten times as much as epoxy in the base, so the beam now fills the upright tops (140 deep instead of 120).

- In the new frame the beam is still the biggest share. Making the uprights rigid would add about 75 / 25 / 85 % in X / Y / Z, and making the base rigid about 70 / 70 / 35 %. The uprights are only 3.1 L each, so per liter they're the next place to add material (wider or deeper, which also grows the base and the enclosure).
- **Uprights.** Optimizing the base and the uprights together (`analysis/topopt_frame.py`, one shared budget, the uprights free to grow anywhere beside the table under the beam) moves about 3 L from the base into the uprights and turns each upright into a raked buttress: the foot runs about 300 mm forward along the base and the front face slopes up to just ahead of the beam (`analysis/figs/frame_34.6_upright.png`). That alone, at the same total material, is +15 / +7 / +24 % in X / Y / Z. With 4 L less material in total the frame ends up about 20 % less stiff than before, so cutting material isn't worth it.
- The castable version drawn now is a solid full-width buttress (one sloped board in the mold, no cores) with its foot 290 mm ahead of the beam face: 5.3 L per upright (5.5 L since the toe got a 20 mm nose). The base was then re-optimized around the longer feet (`analysis/figs/frame2_base_*.png`): it wants full depth under the feet and a wider tie across the split. Total +8.9 L of epoxy granite (about $75) for +39 / +11 / +35 %.
- The base optimization (`analysis/topopt.py`, pockets open to the bottom) puts the base material into girders under the rails, a tie between them behind the split and knees to the sockets, and takes it out of the perimeter walls, the cross rib at the split and the skin. The castable version drawn here has the same volume as before (28.4 L) and is 5 % stiffer on average (at least 3 % in every load case); the beam change adds the rest.
- The cast-in steel is mostly there for the joints. Replacing the base tubes with solid casting would cost only about 1 %; the beam tubes are worth 6-7 %. Six #6 rebars instead of the beam tubes would be about 3 % less stiff, so the tubes stay.
- Cutting epoxy from the base is cheap in money but expensive in stiffness. At the optimized layout's best: 24.5 L matches the old base, 21 L loses 11 %, and below about 18.5 L (the minimum skin, walls and cover around the steel) it falls off fast. Epoxy granite costs about $8.50/L, so even the best case saves about $35. A free-form base with closed box sections (lost foam cores) is only about 8 % stiffer than open pockets at the same volume, which isn't worth the trouble.
- **Weight** (`analysis/weight.py`, `to_light_*`). With the alumina grit in the beam and uprights there was stiffness to spare, so the base was optimized again at smaller budgets. Free-form (ideal) pockets: 27 L of base is 14 kg lighter for -7 / -1 / -2 %, 24 L is 21 kg lighter and still at the sand-only frame's stiffness, 21 L drops below it. Nearly all of it comes out from under the upright feet, which the earlier, larger budget had filled. The castable version keeps a rib across the front of each foot and along the split and leaves room around the tie-rod couplers and the sockets: base 32.8 -> 29.1 L, castings 9 kg lighter, frame -8 / -2 / -4 % against the alumina frame and still +8 / +13 / +16 % over the sand-only one. The simple trims don't pay: 60 mm girders leave under 5 mm of casting beside the rail tubes, and a 55 mm front wall runs the pockets into the legs.

Material and the 8.5 % mix. The model uses E = 30 GPa for the epoxy granite. Published values for well-graded 7-10 % mixes are 25-45 GPa (one commercial mineral casting lists 25 GPa); the university studies use 15-30 % resin with powder fillers and aren't comparable. Granite is about 70 GPa and the epoxy about 3 GPa, so a lower epoxy fraction is as stiff or stiffer as long as every stone is wetted and there are no voids; what it gives up is a little damping (the resin does the damping) and some margin against dry spots. The frame's stiffness scales almost directly with E:

E of the epoxy granite	X	Y	Z
20 GPa	58.0	80.3	72.3
25 GPa	68.3	95.5	84.1
30 GPa (assumed)	**78.2**	**110.1**	**95.5**
35 GPa	87.9	124.4	106.6
40 GPa	97.3	138.4	117.4

So the packing of the mix matters more than the last percent of epoxy. The build guide's jar test and tap-tested bars check both before anything is cast.

Vibration (`analysis/modal.py`, run with `FEA_GRIT=1.37` for the alumina). The frame as drawn on its four feet, with 12 kg of X carriage, Z axis and spindle on the beam blocks and 12 kg of table, vise and work on the Y blocks:

Mode	Frequency	Motion
1	136 Hz	gantry sways side to side (X); base twisting on its feet carries 45 % of it
2	277 Hz	beam rocks front to back (Y)
3	299 Hz	base bends, front to back
4	366 Hz	gantry sway with the base, second form

Bricks this coarse run a little stiff, so the real frequencies are probably 10-20 % lower. Mode 1 is at the bottom of the tooth-pass band for steel (roughly 130-400 Hz: 4,000-8,000 rpm with 2-3 flutes) and modes 2-4 are inside it. That's normal for a machine this size; the frame is still several times stiffer than the spindle and tool (static X/Y/Z above), and chatter on a mill like this usually comes from the spindle, Z axis and tool. If a frequency rings, change the spindle speed by 10-20 % rather than the frame. A solid bench (the base twisting on its feet is in every mode) and sand in the hollow tubes and legs help more than geometry changes.

Lightening holes in the uprights (`analysis/topopt_upright.py`, `compare_uprights.py`). The uprights were optimized again on their own, with the cuts forced to go straight through (windows) or to stop at a 20 mm web on the inner face (pockets from the outside), keeping 90 % and 80 % of their material (run on the frame before the toe and edge cleanup, which added 1-3 %):

Uprights (both)	Removed	X	Y	Z	Mode 1 / 2	Epoxy saved
Solid, as drawn		77.5	107.5	93.0	135 / 264 Hz	
One window each, 90 %	1.05 L, 2.5 kg	75.0	106.5	91.2	136 / 263 Hz	~$3
One outer pocket each, 90 %	1.05 L	75.6	106.8	92.0	136 / 261 Hz	~$3
Two windows each, 80 %	2.1 L, 4.9 kg	71.7	104.8	88.9	136 / 255 Hz	~$6
Two outer pockets each, 80 %	2.1 L	73.1	105.6	90.3	135 / 254 Hz	~$6

The holes land where you'd expect, in the low-stress middle of the buttress just ahead of the front post (`analysis/figs/upright_*.png`), but they don't pay: 10 % of the upright costs 1-3 % of the frame's stiffness and saves about $3 of epoxy (the 3 gal kit is bought either way), and the natural frequencies don't move because the mass that matters is the beam and the head on top. Each window would also need a printed liner. The uprights stay solid; the frame optimization above already moved material into them, not out.

Figures in `analysis/figs` (and `renders/frame_base_underside.png`): `frame_34.6_*` (base and uprights optimized together), `frame2_base_*` (base around the new uprights), `base_current.png` (the previous base), `base_final.png` (solid depth from the top in each column), `base_pocket_*` and `base_free_*` (optimization results at 18-28.5 L), and `tradeoff.png` (base stiffness against base volume), `upright_*` (lightening holes, at 90 and 80 % of the upright).

Rerun it with a Python that has numpy, scipy, matplotlib and scikit-sparse 0.5 or later (older scikit-sparse falls back to a much slower solver):

```
/Applications/FreeCAD.app/Contents/Resources/bin/freecadcmd analysis/voxelize.py   # ->
analysis/vox_current.*
```

```
cd analysis
python baseline.py                                  # stiffness and each module's share (about 1
min)
FEA_VOX=vox_previous sh run_sweep.sh                # base optimizations (about 10 min each)
FEA_VOX=vox_previous python evaluate.py to_*.npz    # table + figures
FEA_VOX=vox_current python whatif.py                # stiffness of the model as drawn
# voxelize with VOX_SKIP=TieRod,DrawRod so the rods in their clearance holes don't count as glued
in
python alumina.py                                   # alumina grit: mix modulus and frame stiffness
FEA_GRIT=1.37 python -c "import topopt; topopt.main('pocket', 24, tag='light_24')"   # lighter base
python weight.py vox_current [vox_...]              # castings mass against stiffness
python modal.py                                     # natural frequencies (about 30 s)
python topopt_upright.py 0.9 [web]                  # upright holes (about 10 min each)
python compare_uprights.py to_upright_*.npz         # their stiffness and frequencies
```

`vox_current` is whatever `build_cnc.py` draws now (`voxelize.py` rewrites it); `vox_previous` is the frame before these changes, which the optimizations and the "previous design" numbers above use. `VOX_P='{"beam_d": 160}'` `VOX_OUT=analysis/vox_test` on the voxelize command tries a parameter change.

Chips and coolant

Stage	What	Where in the model
Collect	Sealed base top; gutters between the uprights and the enclosure walls fall toward a trough across the front, which falls to one outlet	`BaseFrontCasting`, `BaseRearCasting`
Protect	Roll-up 0.1 mm stainless strips in front of and behind the table, a spiral spring cover on the rear screw, a drip shield over the beam rails, brush seals where the motors pass through the panels	`WayCovers`, `CoverRoller*`, `DripShield`, `BrushSeal*`
Drain	The trough drops straight down through the front wall to a cast-in brass nipple over the chip basket	`DrainOutlet`
Clean	Slide-out sump under the base, between four 6 in steel legs cast into the corners: a full-size 4 in stainless steam-table pan (~13 L, ~9 L working). Front to back: 1/3-size perforated pan as the chip basket, magnet bar, printed underflow baffle, 100 um screen in a printed frame, pump	`Sump*`, `Leg*`
Return	24 V brushless submersible pump (switched by the controller's M8 output; no mains in the coolant), push-to-connect at the pump, hose under the base and up the back to a bulkhead in the back panel, along the printed cable chain, a loop down to a manifold on the spindle clamp, two Loc-Line nozzles	`ReturnHose`, `Bulkhead`, `CoolantLines`, `CoolantNozzle*`

To empty or clean the sump, pop the hose off the pump and slide the pan out the front (set `sumpOut` in the `Params` sheet to see it pulled out). The legs raise the machine 117 mm and it still sits on four M12 leveling feet, now in the leg ends. Use a water-soluble coolant and keep it topped up; skim tramp oil off the clean end now and then.

Cable chain. One printed chain on top of the beam carries the coolant line, Z motor, spindle power and spindle water hoses to the carriage (17 links, 38 x 21 outer, 20 mm pitch, R38). Print it in PETG, not PLA. The model shows a simplified link; for the real parts, start from a proven printable parametric chain sized to about 30 x 15 inside and print three links to check the fit before printing the rest. The table and Z axes don't need chains: the table carries no cables and Z uses a short service loop.

Parts that change shape with the axes. The way-cover strips, the screw cover, the cable chain and the nozzle hose are drawn for the home position. The collision check and the renders rebuild them at every pose, but jogging `posX` / `posY` / `posZ` in the GUI won't redraw them; re-run the macro to see them elsewhere.

Cost

Checked against real listings (2026-10-09/10, the sourcing list). The list is in three parts: **1, the frame** (castings, steel, rails, ballscrews, chip protection) about **$1,866** (including $150 of alumina grit for the beam and uprights, and about $200 for the bolt-together mold kit: two sheets of melamine, its hardware, a sheet of XPS foam and the PETG); **2, the electronics and spindle** about **$430** plus the spindle the builder picks ($250-375 for a 1.5 kW 110 V kit, $430-600 for the 2.2 kW kit with a 120 V step-up VFD); **3, the enclosure and flood coolant** about $650-700. The steel and aluminum are priced as remnants and the joint hardware from a hardware store; the remnant prices are estimates. The estimate below was made before that check and is too low; it assumed AliExpress-level prices. It's kept here to show what each cost-down change saves.

Rough estimates in USD at hobby-supplier prices (AliExpress/Amazon-type sources, late 2026). They're not quotes; check current listings. The cost-down column keeps the machine's capability: same travel, rigidity, spindle, closed-loop X/Y, flood coolant and enclosure.

Item	Before	Cost-down	Change
Epoxy + aggregate	$240-315	$200-255	Hollow rear base, 8.5 % epoxy mix (well-graded aggregate + whiting fines), bulk kits
Cast-in steel, rods, dowels, fasteners	$90-140	$90-140	
Rail risers	$60-90	$25-40	Cold-rolled flat bar bedded in epoxy and replicated, instead of MIC6 strips
MIC6 table, carriage, Z plate	$120-180	$120-180	Remnant/drop plate is often much cheaper
Rails + blocks (table, Z)	$110-160	$110-160	Beam rails owned
Ballscrew kits (table, Z)	$70-100	$70-100	Beam kit owned
X/Y closed-loop motors + drivers	$170-220	$140-180	2 Nm 23HS30-E1000: lower inductance, holds torque better at speed, 37 mm shorter
Brackets, couplers	$20-30	$20-30	One bracket owned
Spindle, VFD, clamp, cooling loop	$280-370	$280-370	
Electronics	$150-200	$150-200	
Enclosure	$220-300	$145-210	3 mm ACM walls and roof; polycarbonate only in the door
Coolant system	$105-180	$105-180	
Way covers, seals	$65-105	$65-105	
Lubrication	$40-60	$10-15	Grease gun on the blocks' grease nipples instead of a central pump
Gaskets, inserts, feet	$30-45	$30-45	
Printed cable chain	$3	$3	PETG
Total	**~$1,780-2,500**	**~$1,560-2,210**	

Bigger savings mean giving something up. Options, roughly in order of impact:

- **Phase it.** Build without the enclosure and flood coolant first (mist or air blast). That saves about $250-400 up front. The base still has the gutters and mounting inserts, so both can be added later.
- **Polyester instead of epoxy** for the castings: about half the resin cost, but it shrinks more, so you rely more on the epoxy-replicated mounting surfaces.
- **1.5 kW 110 V spindle** instead of the 2.2 kW you can upgrade to 240 V later: about $40-70 cheaper, less power for steel.
- **Open-loop motors** on X/Y: about $60-80 cheaper, but you lose stall and crash detection.

Reference dimensions

Component	Source	Notes
HGR15 rail, HGH15CA block	HIWIN Linear Guideway catalog G99TE23-2203, HG series (p.38)	Ball-groove positions are not published; estimated.
SFU1204 / SFU1605 nuts, screw end machining	TBI Motion SFU sheet L010974 (via Anaheim Automation)	
BK10/BK12, BF10/BF12 supports	TBI Motion sheets L011175 (BK), L011178 (BF)	BK locknut size estimated. BK12 counterbore depth (1.5) is as printed; worth checking.
DSG16H nut housing	makerstore.cc drawing TR-BS-DSG16-00	
DSG12H nut housing (24 mm bore)	zyltech / vxb listings	Center height and holes estimated.
NEMA 23 motors	StepperOnline drawings 23HS45-4204D-E1000, 23HS30-5004D-E1000, 23HS30-3004S	
Motor bracket	No published drawing	Sized from kit listings: motor face ~47 mm from the BK.
D25 L30 coupler	Seller listings (5 N·m, 8x10 / 6.35x10 bores)	Hub depth estimated.
GDZ80-2.2 spindle	StepperOnline drawings GDZ80-2.2A/B	Some features scaled from the drawing (±1 mm). Body length varies by seller (213/230/240): measure yours.
80 mm cast clamp	cnconline.co.za 80 mm spindle bracket drawing	148 W x 80 D, 14 foot, bore center 50 off the foot.
ER20 nut	DIN 6499 / spindle drawing	Chinese spindles ship a 30 AF hex nut.
2020 extrusion	Misumi HFS5-2020 catalog p.2-511	Owned V-slot is OpenBuilds profile (6.25 throat).

Before casting anything, measure the parts you actually have, especially the owned ANWOK rails, blocks and SFU1204 kit. Clone parts can differ from these catalogs by a millimeter or two.